the UF leadership and to manage better relationships with all ethnic groups.[59] Such requests, however, did not translate into serious diplomatic pressure (both Russia and Iran supported Karzai and wanted to strengthen him further despite being wary of his political marginalisation of non-Pashtuns leaders). This aspect is reflected in the vast difference between what Indian security and diplomatic officials thought in private and what they said in public about Karzai. Publicly, the MEA reported in 2007 that Afghanistan under Karzai, 'had made progress towards internal stability in a democratic and pluralistic framework', despite the Taliban's audacious revival.[60] But privately, senior MEA and R&AW officials thought that Karzai was walking a delicate political line by politicking against non-Pashtun candidates and was 'not advancing the cause of peace and stability that much'.[61] Even top retired Indian officials such as Brajesh Mishra and M. K. Rasgotra, were critical of Karzai for being unable to 'stabilize Afghanistan' in private conversations with serving US officials.[62] Nonetheless, India only increased its support for Karzai and signed the Strategic Partnership Agreement (SPA) with Kabul in October 2011. For Rakesh Sood, India's ambassador to Afghanistan (2005–08), India was engaging with the legitimate Afghan government recognised by the international community. Sood firmly believed that playing favourites along partisan lines was not in the character of India's foreign policy (a contestable claim).[63] Mukhopadhaya also asserts that despite enlarging its humanitarian and developmental footprint, India steered clear from Afghanistan's internal politics.[64] In November 2009, in the fog of debate about reconciliation with the Taliban, joint secretary Yash K. Sinha told his US counterpart that India was not interested in 'micromanaging' Karzai.[65] Sensitive about Afghanistan's sovereignty, India refused to take decisions that could be perceived as being biased in the domestic Afghan context. New Delhi was not interested in Afghanistan's political processes, it just wanted unambiguous outcomes, which were to ensure that no political leaders that were dependent on Pakistan for sustenance, entered the government with ease.

Such balancing between Afghanistan's contradictory desires of deeper and decisive Indian engagement (often on partisan lines) on one hand, and not being seen as intrusive and undermining Afghan sovereignty on the other hand, was a diplomatic tightrope. Different Afghan factions secretly wanted India to adopt a